Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

1 Thessalonians

1 Thessalonians 1:1

- Ancient letters started with the author's name, the names of the recipients, and a greeting.
- Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy started this church (Acts 17:1–9).
- grace and peace: The greeting summarizes the Christian's experience of the good news about Jesus.

1 Thessalonians 1:2

We always thank God for all of you: This is the first of three times the apostle Paul gives thanks for the church (see 2:13; 3:9).

1 Thessalonians 1:2–10

The apostle Paul first thanks God for the faith, love, and hope of the Thessalonian Christians (1:2–3). Then he recalls how they heard the good news about Jesus (1:4–5), and how they accepted its message (1:6–10). Paul mentions these themes again in 2:1–12 and 2:13–16.

1 Thessalonians 1:3

The apostle Paul was grateful because the Thessalonians showed loyal work, deeds of love, and steady hope (see 3:6; 5:8; 2 Thessalonians 1:3–4).

1 Thessalonians 1:4

Brothers: The Greek word adelphoi is a general term for family members, including both males and females.

1 Thessalonians 1:5

God called the Thessalonians through the announcement of the good news about Jesus (2 Thessalonians 2:13–14). The Holy Spirit convinced the listeners that the message was true (1 Corinthians 2:4–5; 1 Peter 1:12).

1 Thessalonians 1:6

The Thessalonians encountered great suffering from their peers because they accepted the good news about Jesus (2:14; 3:3–4). However, by following the example of the apostles and the Lord himself, they found the joy of the Holy Spirit (Matthew 5:11–12; Romans 8:17; 12:12; Philippians 2:17; 1 Peter 4:13–14).

1 Thessalonians 1:7–8

The Thessalonians' strong faith and proclamation of the good news about Jesus spread through Macedonia and Achaia.

1 Thessalonians 1:9

Among the Gentiles (non-Jewish people), the apostles called people to turn away from false gods and worship the living and true God, who created all things (Acts 14:11–18; 17:22–31; 19:23–41). In a society where many religions existed side by side, it was unusual to ask people to abandon the gods worshiped by their families and communities (see Jeremiah 10:8–10; 1 Corinthians 8:4–6).

1 Thessalonians 1:10

The resurrection of Jesus from the dead was central to the apostles' preaching (4:14; Acts 2:32; 3:15; 10:40; 13:29–30; 1 Corinthians 15:3–8). It formed the basis for confidence in the return of Jesus (see 1 Thessalonians 5:9; 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10).

1 Thessalonians 2:1

The Greek word for visit often means the process of entering a city. Ancient speakers were famous for their grand entrances into cities. Paul's arrival in Thessalonica should be judged by its successful outcomes, not by its lack of display or ceremony.

1 Thessalonians 2:1–3.13

The letter begins by discussing the character of Paul and his associates, as well as how the Thessalonians accepted the good news (2:1–12; 13–16).

It emphasizes Paul's genuine care for the church, mentioning:

- his efforts to visit them again (2:17–20), and
- his choice to send Timothy when he could not go himself (3:1–5).

It concludes with the apostle Paul's happiness about Timothy's positive report and his prayers to return to the church (3:6–9; 10–13). This detailed defense addresses criticisms of Paul's sudden departure and long absence.

1 Thessalonians 2:2

Paul and Silvanus encountered shame and pain in Philippi (Acts 16:19–40). Yet, they were brave and preached with confidence in Thessalonica.

1 Thessalonians 2:4

In the ancient world, people in public office were publicly tested and approved for their work. The Thessalonians and God served as two witnesses to the purity of Paul's motives. (2:3).

1 Thessalonians 2:5

Flattery was often used to gain money from others. Paul denies flattering the Thessalonians to receive money. He calls both the Thessalonians and God as witnesses (see 2:10; Deuteronomy 19:15; 2 Corinthians 13:1; 1 Timothy 5:19).

1 Thessalonians 2:7

we were gentle among you: Some manuscripts say we were like infants. Paul and his associates did not use their authority as apostles to make demands (see Matthew 20:25–28).

1 Thessalonians 2:9

Paul and his associates worked with their hands to support themselves while in the city (see Acts 18:1–4; 1 Corinthians 9:12–18). They did this to set an example for the Thessalonians (2 Thessalonians 3:8–9). They also wanted to avoid being an economic burden to them.

1 Thessalonians 2:10

Both God and the Thessalonians were witnesses that Paul behaved in a dedicated and honest way (see 2:5). These qualities come from terms used in ancient literature to describe obedience to both divine and human laws.

1 Thessalonians 2:11

In the ancient world, fathers had a key role in teaching and modeling moral living to children. Roman fathers could be strict. But the historian Plutarch advised Greek fathers to use praise, reason, encouragement, and good advice to teach children to avoid bad behavior and practice good values. Paul describes himself as this type of father to the Thessalonians.

1 Thessalonians 2:12

God would consider a life worthy if it aligns with the high standards he expects from those called to share his own kingdom and glory (4:7; Romans 8:17–18; Colossians 1:27; 2 Thessalonians 2:14).

1 Thessalonians 2:13

Paul thanks the Thessalonians again (see 1:2; 3:9). This was because they accepted the apostles' message as more than human ideas. They understood it was the word of God (1:5; 2 Thes 2:14; 2 Cor 5:20).

1 Thessalonians 2:14

The Thessalonian Christians suffered persecution. Their actions showed that they accepted the word of God (1:6). By suffering persecution, the Thessalonians followed the pattern of the apostles, the churches in Judea, and Christ himself (Acts 8:1).

1 Thessalonians 2:15

Paul was not opposed to the Jewish people. Out of love for them, he prayed for their salvation (Romans 9:1–5; 10:1). However, he knew some Jews had a role in the deaths of God's messengers, including the Lord Jesus and some prophets (1 Kings 19:10; Acts 7:52). Some Jews had also persecuted the apostles in Thessalonica (Acts 17:10; 2 Corinthians 11:26).

1 Thessalonians 2:16

- The mission to the Gentiles was one of the most important issues in the early church (Acts 11:18; 13:46–49; 28:28; Romans 1:16).
- Judgment comes when sins increase to full capacity (Genesis 15:16; Daniel 8:23; compare Matthew 23:31–36).

1 Thessalonians 2:17

- torn away: Paul talks about his unexpected departure from Thessalonica as depriving the new Christians of their spiritual parents (see Acts 17:10). However, this absence was not neglect. Paul's attempts to return to the church show the separation was not on purpose (compare Philippians 1:7; Colossians 2:5).

1 Thessalonians 2:18

Paul tried to return to the Thessalonian church many times. Despite Satan's opposition, both Timothy and Paul eventually visited the church again (see Romans 16:20; 2 Corinthians 2:11; Ephesians 6:10–12; 1 Thessalonians 3:2, 5; Acts 20:1–3).

1 Thessalonians 2:19

In the Greek and Roman world, a crown was given to those who received great civic honor or who were victorious in athletic games.

1 Thessalonians 2:20

Paul regards the Thessalonian Christians, not his own achievements, as his source of glory and joy (3:9).

1 Thessalonians 3:1–5

After preaching in Berea, Paul left Macedonia and sailed to Athens. He instructed Silas and Timothy to join him soon (Acts 17:13–15). Timothy returned to Thessalonica because Paul had become more concerned about the Thessalonian church (1 Thessalonians 3:2; 3:1, 5).

1 Thessalonians 3:3

we are destined for this: Suffering for the faith is often part of a Christian's life (1:6; 2:14; Philippians 1:29; 1 Peter 1:6; 2:21; 3:17; 4:19).

1 Thessalonians 3:5

Paul had concern that Satan, the tempter, had weakened the Thessalonians' faith (Mark 1:13; 1 Corinthians 7:5; 1 Thessalonians 3:2, 6, 8). He was checking to make sure his efforts among them were not useless (Galatians 2:2; Philippians 2:16).

1 Thessalonians 3:6

Paul wrote 1 Thessalonians from Corinth soon after Timothy came back from Thessalonica (3:2, 5; Acts 18:5). Timothy's report brought good news about the Thessalonians' faith, love, perseverance, and hope (1 Thessalonians 3:8; see also 5:8; 2 Thessalonians 1:3–4).

1 Thessalonians 3:8

Paul felt troubled by his current situation (3:7) and deeply concerned for the church (3:1, 5). He felt relieved to hear that the Thessalonians remained strong and firm in the Lord, even while suffering (2:14; 3:3–4).

1 Thessalonians 3:11

Paul prays to return to Thessalonica soon (3:10). He addresses both the Father and the Lord Jesus, which implies that Jesus is divine.

1 Thessalonians 3:12

This church was known for their love for each other as members of God's family (4:9; 2 Thessalonians 1:3–4). Paul prays that their love will increase and reach those outside the Christian community even when they suffer persecution (see 1 Thessalonians 5:15; Galatians 6:10; 2 Timothy 2:24; Titus 3:2).

1 Thessalonians 3:13

- In the final part of this prayer, Paul prays that their hearts will be strong, innocent, and holy. Here, the word hearts means their behavior and moral strength (3:11–13; Matthew 5:8; Acts 15:9; Hebrews 10:22).
- When Jesus comes, he will be with all his holy people. This may mean angels (Deuteronomy 33:2; Psalm 89:5, 7; Daniel 4:13; 8:13; Matthew 13:41; Mark 8:38; 13:26–27; 2 Thessalonians 1:7).

1 Thessalonians 4:1–2

- we ask and encourage you: Paul emphasizes the authority of his teaching by speaking in the name of the Lord Jesus.
- For you know the instructions we gave: Ancient letters often reminded recipients of what they already knew. Paul reminds the Thessalonians of matters requiring them to obey (4:11; 2 Thessalonians 3:4, 6, 10, 12).

1 Thessalonians 4:1–5.22

The second part of the letter discusses Timothy's news about the church and the questions the Christians had for Paul.

Paul addresses:

- the problem of sexual immorality (4:3–8) before responding to the Thessalonians' questions about love for other Christians (4:9–12),
- the fate of Christians who have died (4:13–18), and
- the timing of "the Day of the Lord" (5:1–11).

Paul offers advice on topics such as leadership and community relations, the relationship with the Lord, and prophecy (5:12–22).

1 Thessalonians 4:3

it is God's will that you should be holy: Christian ethics focus on doing God's will, not on philosophical ideas about virtue (Romans 12:1–2; Ephesians 6:6; Hebrews 10:36; 13:20–21). Holiness affects every part of a person's life (1 Thessalonians 4:4, 7; 5:23). Here, it means restraint from sexual sin (Greek porneia, meaning any sexual union or activity outside marriage).

1 Thessalonians 4:4

control his own body: Self-control earns honor from others and from God (Romans 12:10; Romans 2:7; 1 Peter 5:4, 6).

1 Thessalonians 4:5

- Ignoring God and his teachings leads to moral corruption (Romans 1:18–32; Ephesians 4:17–18).
- lustful passion: In the ancient Mediterranean world, people often tolerated sexual immorality. Prostitution was legal, but having sexual relations with another man's wife was not. Roman marriage customs permitted men, but not women, to have sexual affairs. In contrast to Roman customs, Jewish and Christian writers forbade all sexual activity outside of marriage (Acts 15:20; 1 Corinthians 6:12–20; Colossians 3:5–6).

1 Thessalonians 4:7

not ... impurity ... but ... holiness: Compare with 1:4; 2:12; 5:23–24; 2 Thessalonians 2:13–14; 1 Peter 1:15–16.

1 Thessalonians 4:8

- Rejecting Paul's teachings on these matters was the same as rejecting God.
- The Holy Spirit helps Christians live according to God's will (Ezekiel 36:27; Romans 8:1–4; Galatians 5:16; 1 John 3:24).

1 Thessalonians 4:9

you yourselves have been taught by God to love one another (see Isaiah 54:13):

- through the teachings of Jesus (John 13:34–35),
- through the death of Jesus on the cross (Romans 5:8; Ephesians 5:1–2), and
- through the Holy Spirit (Romans 5:5; Galatians 5:22).

1 Thessalonians 4:9–5.11

Paul answers questions from the Thessalonians (see 1 Corinthians 7:1), questions about:

- loving each other (1 Thessalonians 4:9–12)
- the destiny of Christians who have died (4:13–18), and
- the timing of the day the Lord will return (5:1–11).

1 Thessalonians 4:10

The Thessalonian Christians showed love to all Christians in Macedonia, including Philippi and Berea, by providing financial help (see also 1:7–8 and 2 Corinthians 8:1–5).

1 Thessalonians 4:11

- to live quietly means being worthy of respect and not causing problems in the community.
- work with your hands: The apostle Paul had previously instructed through his teaching and personal example that they should earn their own living (see Thessalonians 3:7–9; 10).

1 Thessalonians 4:12

Not relying on non-Christians for financial help and behaving properly toward them will earn the respect of non-Christians (see Romans 13:13; 1 Corinthians 5:12–13; Colossians 4:5).

1 Thessalonians 4:13

- those who sleep in death (literally those who have fallen asleep; also in 4:14): In Greek, Jewish, and Christian literature, sleep often means death (Daniel 12:2; Matthew 27:52). Personal existence continues after death (Luke 23:40–43; Acts 7:55–60; 2 Corinthians 5:6–10; Philippians 1:20–24; Revelation 6:9–11). Those who have died await the resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:23).
- grieve like the rest, who are without hope: Ancient letters of comfort advised those in grief not to become overwhelmed by grief, as they could not prevent death. Paul does not forbid grief but encourages Christians to avoid the kind of grief typical of those without hope in God (see John 16:6, 20; Philippians 2:27).

1 Thessalonians 4:14

- died and rose again: The death and resurrection of Jesus is the foundation for hope despite the reality of death, guaranteed by Christ's resurrection (1 Corinthians 15).
- God will bring with Jesus those: Refers to the resurrection of Christians (1 Thessalonians 4:16).

1 Thessalonians 4:15

- By the word of the Lord: The teachings of Jesus gave Paul assurance for the Thessalonians (see Matthew 24:29–31, 40–41).
- will by no means precede: Paul assures the Thessalonians that when the Lord returns, the dead will not be at a disadvantage. They will participate equally in the resurrection.
- In talking about the return of Jesus, Paul uses a Greek term (parousia). It is often used to describe an emperor or king's grand arrival in a city (see 1 Thessalonians 4:17).

1 Thessalonians 4:16

with the trumpet of God: God's trumpet will announce the resurrection, just as it once announced Israel's rescue (Zephaniah 1:16; Zechariah 9:14). In the future, it will announce the gathering of God's people from

the farthest ends of the earth and heaven (Matthew 24:31; compare 1 Corinthians 15:52).

1 Thessalonians 4:17

to meet: This implies the custom of sending an official delegation to welcome a visiting leader and accompany him into the city (Matthew 25:6, 10; Acts 28:15–16).

1 Thessalonians 4:18

Paul teaches about the end of history to help Christians support each other when encountering death. He does not encourage guessing about the end of time.

1 Thessalonians 5:1

Questions about how and when these events will happen occupied the thoughts of both Jewish and Christian people (Daniel 12:6; Matthew 24:3; Luke 17:20; Acts 1:6; 1 Peter 1:10–11).

1 Thessalonians 5:2

- Paul reminds them of the teachings they already received (3:3–4).
- the Day of the Lord: The day when God will judge humanity and save his people (Isaiah 13:6, 9; Ezekiel 30:3; Joel 2:21–32; 3:18; Zechariah 14).
- like a thief in the night: Compare Matthew 24:43–44; Luke 12:39–40; 2 Peter 3:10; Revelation 3:3; 16:15.

1 Thessalonians 5:3

"Peace and security": This phrase was common during the time of the pax Romana (Roman peace). Despite this assumption of security, God's final judgment arrives suddenly and no one can avoid it.

1 Thessalonians 5:4

The day of the Lord will not surprise Christians. This is not because they know exactly when Jesus will come again, but because they are spiritually ready.

1 Thessalonians 5:5

- sons of the light: God freed the Thessalonian Christians from spiritual darkness (John 12:36; Acts 26:18; Ephesians 5:8; 1 Peter 2:9).
- sons of the day: They belong to God's new order (Romans 13:12).
- to the night or to the darkness: These refer to living a life of sin (see 1 Thessalonians 5:6–8).

1 Thessalonians 5:6

let us remain awake and sober: Paul is echoing the way Jesus called his people to be alert and to prepare themselves with moral living. This is because no one will not know the exact day of his return (Matthew 24:42, 44; 25:13; compare 1 Peter 1:13).

1 Thessalonians 5:7

Sleep means being lazy in morals (5:6). Being drunk is a metaphor for lacking self-control. The day of the Lord will surprise these people (5:4; Matthew 24:48–51).

1 Thessalonians 5:8

breastplate ... helmet: (Isaiah 59:17; Ephesians 6:11–17): These pieces of armor represent living a moral life (Romans 13:12; 2 Corinthians 6:7; 10:3–5; 2 Timothy 2:3–4). The Christian "soldier" uses the equipment of the virtues of faith, love, and hope (see 1 Thessalonians 1:3; 3:6; 1 Corinthians 13:13; 2 Thessalonians 1:3–4).

1 Thessalonians 5:9

God's wrath shows his judgment against evil (1:10; 2:16; Romans 5:9; see 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10; 2:8). However, God plans for Christians to receive salvation, not encounter his wrath (2 Thessalonians 2:13–14). Christians will not suffer the terrors of the day of the Lord (1 Thessalonians 5:1–3).

1 Thessalonians 5:10

- The promise that Christians will live with him forever is based on Christ's resurrection (4:14).
- awake or asleep: This refers to living and dead Christians (4:13–15) rather than people's moral condition (as in 5:6–7).

1 Thessalonians 5:11

Paul wants the Thessalonians to use the teachings about the end of time to encourage and build up one another (see 4:18). He does not want them to speculate about when the Lord will return.

1 Thessalonians 5:12

- acknowledge: This may refer to honoring church leaders or recognizing new leaders in the church (1 Corinthians 16:15–16). True leaders work diligently and govern to serve (1 Timothy 4:10; 5:17; Matthew 20:25–28). They lead, help, and protect the church (Romans 16:1–2; 1 Timothy 3:4–5, 12).
- who give you instruction: Leaders correct moral errors and protect the church against false doctrine (Acts 20:31; 1 Corinthians 4:14; Colossians 1:28).

1 Thessalonians 5:13

- Leaders should receive honor and love for what they do, not just their rank.
- Live in peace: Teaching about community peace and harmony was common in ancient moral lessons. Harmony between Christians and leaders was crucial because of the persecution the church experienced (2:14).

1 Thessalonians 5:14

- The leaders are not the only ones responsible for the congregation's moral progress (4:18; 5:11). Paul urged the church to warn those who are lazy (unruly), and those who did not follow the apostles' instructions (see 2 Thessalonians 3:6–15).
- encourage the fainthearted, help the weak: Greek society thought poorly of people perceived as weak in some way.
- Instead of being annoyed, Christians should be patient in their relationships (Galatians 5:23; Ephesians 4:2).

1 Thessalonians 5:15

Jesus and the apostles advised against revenge (Matthew 5:38–48; Luke 6:27–36; Romans 12:17–21; 1 Peter 3:9). In contrast, the Roman author Seneca believed revenge was necessary to restore lost social honor. Paul urged Christians to do good to everyone, including church members and those outside the Christian community, even those who persecuted them (1 Thessalonians 2:14; see 3:12; Galatians 6:10).

1 Thessalonians 5:17

Pray without ceasing means to be spiritually alert and persist in prayer (1:2; Luke 18:1; Romans 12:12; Ephesians 6:18). Christians don't need to speak words of prayer every moment, but they should cultivate an attitude of prayer at all times.

1 Thessalonians 5:18

Give thanks: God is in total control and can redeem any situation (Romans 8:28). Paul is reminding the Thessalonians to be grateful in all circumstances, good or bad. Being grateful in all circumstances is submission to God's will.

1 Thessalonians 5:19

Do not extinguish the Spirit: Paul commands the Thessalonian Christians to keep the Spirit's presence active among them by allowing prophecy in the church (Matthew 3:11; Acts 2:3; 2 Timothy 1:6; Jeremiah 20:9; 1 John 4:1–2).

1 Thessalonians 5:20–21

Do not treat prophecies with contempt: No one should dismiss prophecy intended to spiritually strengthen the church (1 Corinthians 14:1–4). Instead, the Thessalonians should evaluate the prophecies to understand where they come from. Paul says they should make sure any prophecies align with the apostles' teachings (1 Corinthians 12:10; 14:29; 2 Thessalonians 2:2; 1 John 4:1–3). The church should also assess the character of those who deliver the prophecies (Matthew 7:15–20).

Early Christian teaching stated, "Not everyone who speaks about spiritual things is a prophet, but only if the person's behavior is like the Lord" (Didache 11:8). Paul encourages the Thessalonians to hold fast to what is good. Specifically, this means to test prophecies to see if they prove true.

1 Thessalonians 5:22

They should reject every form of evil, especially false prophecies (5:19–21).

1 Thessalonians 5:23

God helps Christians become holy (3:11–13). His work to sanctify extends to the spirit, soul, and body, which means all parts of human life (see also Matthew 10:28; Mark 12:30; 1 Corinthians 7:34).

1 Thessalonians 5:23–28

Greek and Roman letters ended with a wish for the recipient's good health. Jewish letters concluded with a blessing of peace. Paul ends his letter with a Christian version of these practices.

1 Thessalonians 5:24

He will do it: Paul places complete trust in God's faithful character (1 Corinthians 1:9; 2 Thessalonians 3:3; 2 Timothy 2:13; 1 John 1:9).

1 Thessalonians 5:26

a holy kiss (see also Romans 16:16; 1 Corinthians 16:20; 2 Corinthians 13:12; 1 Peter 5:14): People often greeted each other by kissing on the cheek or forehead. This showed honor, friendship, and love among family members (Mark 14:44–45; Luke 7:36–47; 15:20; Acts 20:37).

1 Thessalonians 5:27

have this letter read: People read Scripture out loud in synagogues (local Jewish places of worship) and churches (Luke 4:16; Acts 13:15; 1 Timothy 4:13). Paul

1 Thessalonians 5:28

encouraged the practice of reading his letters out loud to the entire congregation (Colossians 4:16).

1 Thessalonians 5:28

Paul adds to the usual greeting by including a blessing of grace at the end of his letters (Romans 16:20; 1 Corinthians 16:23; Galatians 6:18; Ephesians 6:24; 2 Thessalonians 3:18).